

Booked but Not Reordered

Grill Order and Wait Time at a Courtyard Barbecue, Before and After a Sign-Up Board

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The problem

A shared courtyard barbecue runs on an unwritten first-arrived, first-grilled convention nobody can recite but nobody violates. A sign-up booking board promises to formalise that order. Whether formalising an unwritten queue changes what actually happens at the grill is untested.

What we set out to test

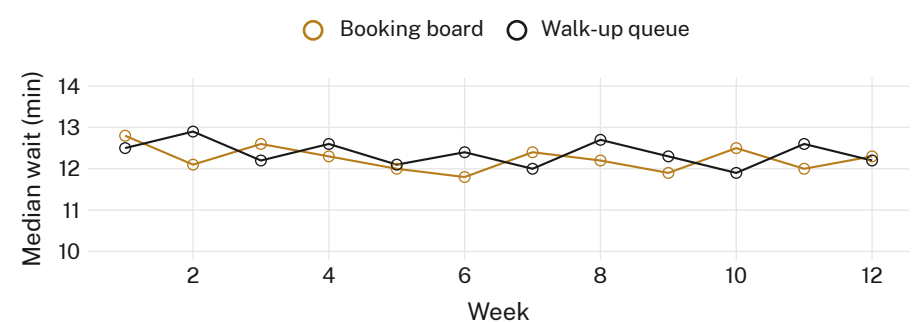
- Whether a sign-up booking board changes the order residents actually grill in, relative to arrival order
- Whether the board shortens or reshuffles the wait between arriving and reaching the grill
- What arrival-order baseline any booking effect should be judged against

Study design

- 16 courtyard barbecues, one apartment-complex network · 812 logged grill turns over 12 weeks
- 8 courtyards fitted with a QR sign-up board at week 5; 8 held as walk-up-only controls throughout
- Arrival order and grill-turn order independently logged each session; reserved slot times cross-checked against actual turn order

Findings

Grill-turn order tracked arrival order closely in both arms ($\rho = 0.81$ boarded, 0.83 walk-up), and median wait held near 12 minutes throughout. Just 34% of booked slots were claimed in their reserved order.



Median wait time held between 11.8 and 12.9 minutes in both arms across all 12 weeks, including the 8 weeks after the sign-up board went live in the intervention cohort at week 5.

Implications & where next

A booking board changes what a resident can point to, not what they do at the grill. The reservation queue was absorbed into the arrival queue rather than the reverse, and unclaimed reserved slots reverted to whoever was already standing there. Next: test whether an enforced no-show penalty moves grill order where the QR code alone did not.

Selected references

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No resident identity retained; turns logged by queue position only, reservations drawn from the board's own log, not resident report.

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